

Marsden Ball Pursuits — Lying Down

Smooth-pursuit eye training for tennis · Athlete Guide

Why this drill

In tennis your eyes must lock onto the ball and **track it smoothly** from your opponent's racquet to your strings — through the bounce, the spin, and the rise off the court. Marsden ball pursuits train exactly that: keeping a moving target sharp and centered without your eyes jumping or lagging. Doing it **lying down** removes your neck, posture, and balance, so your eyes do all the work — building cleaner tracking that transfers to earlier contact, better timing, and fewer mishits.

What you need & how to set up

- A **Marsden ball** (or any soft ball, ~3 in.) hung on a string from the ceiling, a door frame, or a hook. Letters/numbers on it are a bonus.
- Hang it so it dangles **roughly 18–24 inches above your eyes** when you lie on your back.
- Lie down flat (floor or bench), face up, head still and relaxed.
- Good light. Take your glasses off only if you normally play without them.

How to do it

1

Find the ball

Lie back and look straight up at the ball. Let your eyes settle on one spot on it — a letter, a mark, or the center.

2

Start the swing

Reach up and give the ball a gentle push so it swings side to side (like a slow pendulum). Keep your head and hands still after that.

3

Track, don't jump

Follow the ball with your eyes only — smooth and continuous, like pouring water. Keep that one spot on the ball in focus the whole way across. No blinking it back into place.

4

Stay sharp through the ends

The ball moves slowest at each end and fastest in the middle. Most people lose it in the middle — stay glued to it there. Keep it single and clear, never doubled or blurry.

5

Change the path

After ~30 seconds, restart the swing in a new direction: side-to-side, then toward-and-away (ball coming at your nose and back), then a circle, then a diagonal.

Dose

- **3–4 directions** per session (side, depth, circle, diagonal)
- **~30 sec** of smooth tracking each
- **Rest 15 sec** between sets — close your eyes
- **4–5 days/week.** Best as a warm-up before hitting

Form cues

- Keep the ball **single and clear** — if it doubles or blurs, slow the swing
- **Head dead still** — only the eyes move
- **Breathe.** Don't hold your breath or clench your jaw
- Eyes **lead** the ball, never chase it from behind

Make it harder (only when it feels easy)

- **Call the letter.** Read a letter or number off the ball each time it passes your eyes.
- **Speed up the swing** a little — keep it clear at the faster pace.
- **Add depth.** Swing it toward and away from your nose; hold focus as it gets close.
- **Split attention.** Track the ball while a partner taps your foot or calls out numbers for you to answer.
- **Then stand up.** Once lying-down feels automatic, repeat seated, then standing in your ready position.

Stop if you feel dizzy, nauseous, or get a headache — shorten the sets and build up slowly. Smooth tracking beats fast tracking, every time.